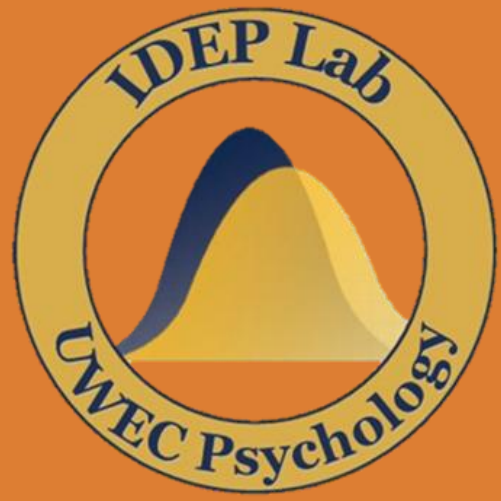




WOMEN AND MEN, HARM AND CENSORIOUSNESS:

SEX DIFFERENTIATED REACTIONS TO INFORMATION ABOUT SEX DIFFERENCES

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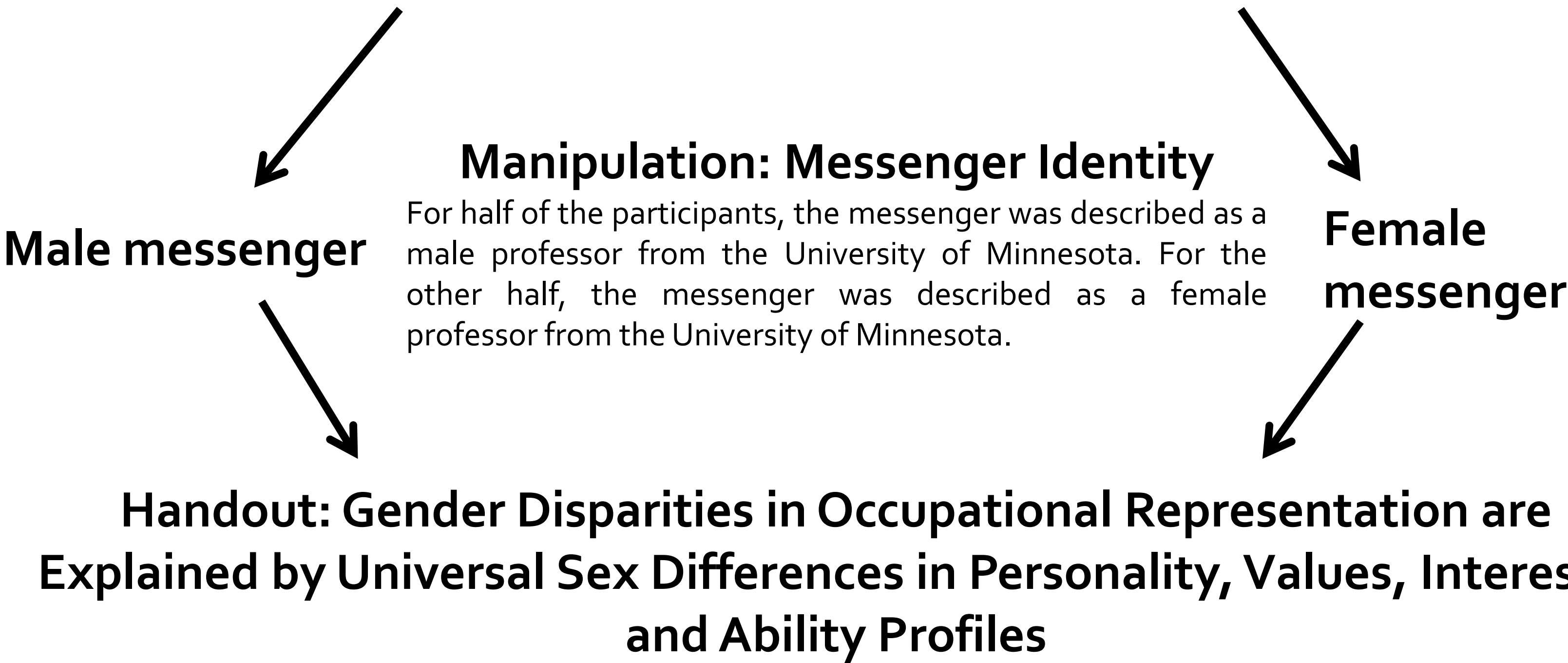
Introduction

- Some of the most controversial conclusions in psychology involve evolutionary or genetic explanations for sex differences in educational-vocational outcomes (Buss & von Hippel, 2018; Clark et al., under review); indeed, individuals have been fired for suggesting that sex differences in these outcomes are biological.
- In this study, we were interested in reactions to that exact kind of controversial information depending upon the messenger’s gender identity and participants’ gender identity, political leaning, and belief that words can cause harm.
- Using one college student sample (N=396, $M_{age}=20.4$) and one sample of community adults from MTurk (N=154, $M_{age}=44.4$), we tested several hypotheses: (1) Compared to men, women will be (1a) less receptive to and (1b) more censorious toward the messenger and the message, (2) participants will be (2a) less receptive to and (2b) more censorious toward a male messenger than female messenger, (3) the effect of a male versus female messenger on (3a) receptivity and (3b) censoriousness will be stronger for women than for men, (4) compared to politically right-leaning participants, left-leaning participants will be (4a) less receptive to and (4b) more censorious toward the messenger and message, and (5) compared to those with weaker belief that words can cause harm, participants with stronger belief that words can cause harm will be (5a) less receptive to and (5b) more censorious toward the messenger and message.

Method

Setup: Controversial Information

Participants were asked to imagine having a conversation with their roommate in which the roommate describes having a guest messenger in one of their classes earlier that day to talk about causes of male overrepresentation in various high-level jobs.



Then, participants were asked to review a handout detailing the messenger’s points. The handout was identical in the two conditions, except for the name listed at the very top of the handout, which reinforced the manipulation of messenger sex as male (Professor Kevin Gilden, PhD) or female (Professor Kathryn Gilden, PhD). The handout began with the claim that women in STEM are no longer discriminated against in terms of hiring and publishing, and that sex differences observed in STEM and at high levels of the corporate ladder are better explained by evolved differences between men and women in personality traits, life values, work preferences, lifestyle preferences, and specific cognitive abilities. The handout included five bullets elaborating these arguments, as well as supporting references.

Dependent Variables: Receptivity to the messenger and their message and censorious toward the messenger and their message

Participants then provided their reactions. There were two subsets of items, as shown below:

Dependent Variable	Example Items	College Student Sample	Community Adults Sample
Overall Receptivity (11 items)	The messenger is well-educated on sex differences. The messenger is credible. The messenger is an advocate for women’s rights. The arguments made in the handout are logical. The information on the handout is offensive. (Rev)	$\alpha = .90$	$\alpha = .94$
Censoriousness (4 items)	This messenger should be censored. The information on this handout should be shared with others. (Rev)	$\alpha = .89$	$\alpha = .82$

Note. All items were on a seven-point scale ranging from Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree.

Participant Variables: Gender Identity, Words Can Harm, Political Orientation

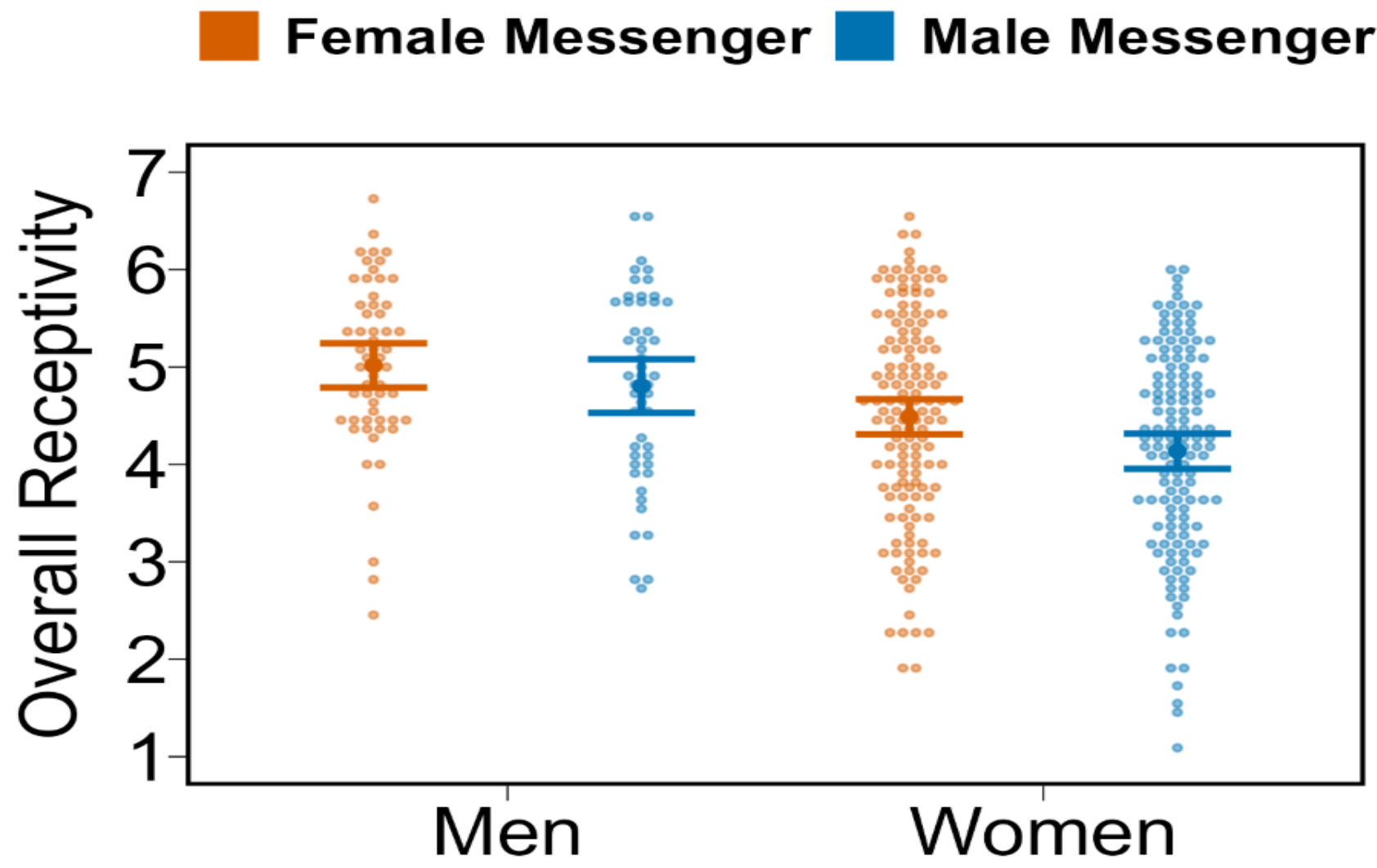
Participants then responded to a set of statements designed to measure the degree to which they believe that words can cause harm (Bellet et al., 2018; e.g., I could be emotionally scarred by something I read.) Last, participants filled out a brief demographics section (gender, age, race, political orientation). Political orientation was measured on a 5-point Likert scale (far left, liberal, centrist, conservative, far right).

Attention Check

Participants were asked how closely they read the handout. Those who said “I did not read it” were omitted from analysis and are not included in the sample sizes reported above. We retained participants who said they skimmed it, read it, or read it carefully.

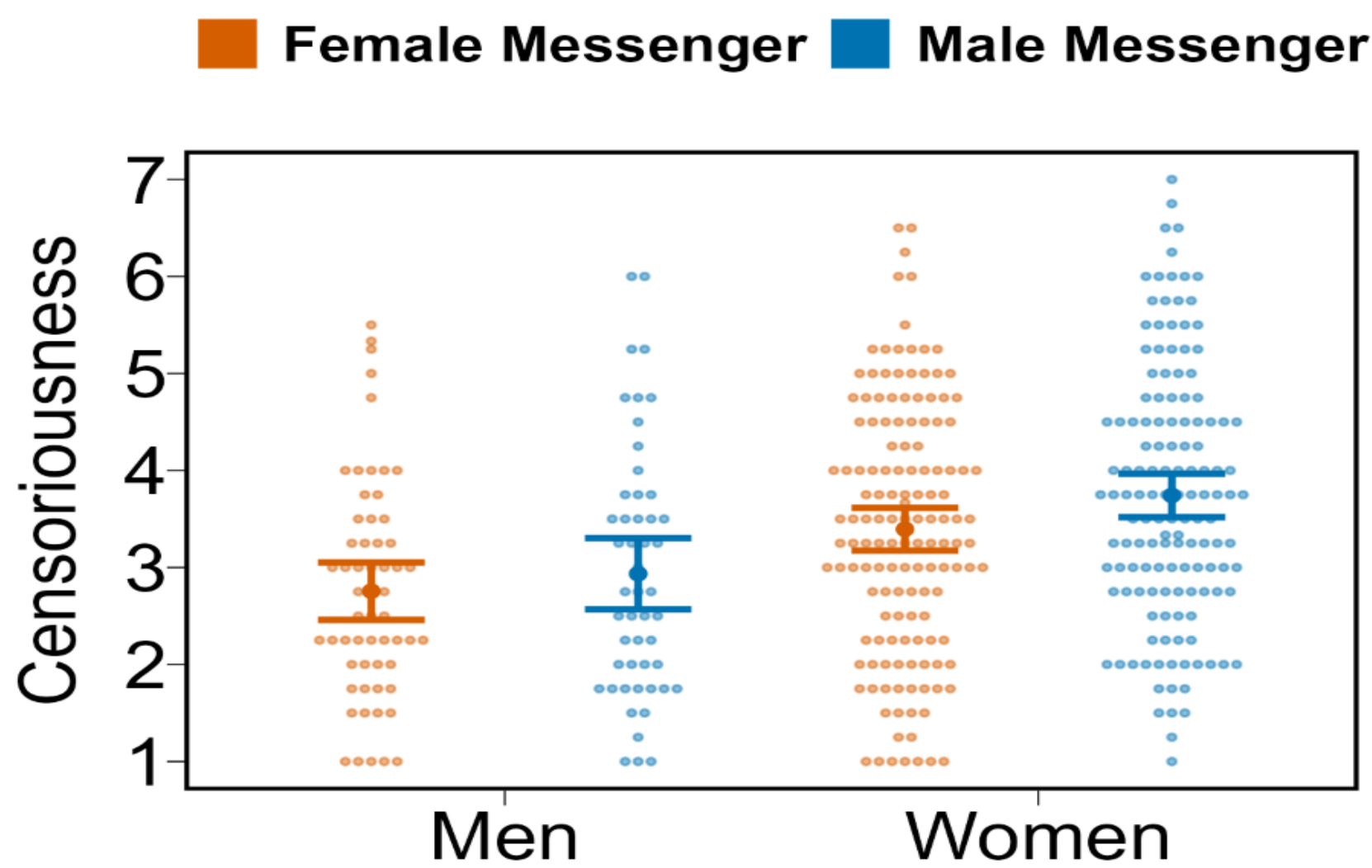
Results

College students: (1a:) Women were less receptive to the messenger than men ($p < .001$, $d = .59$) and (2a:) participants were less receptive to the male messenger than female messenger ($p = .016$, $d = .31$).



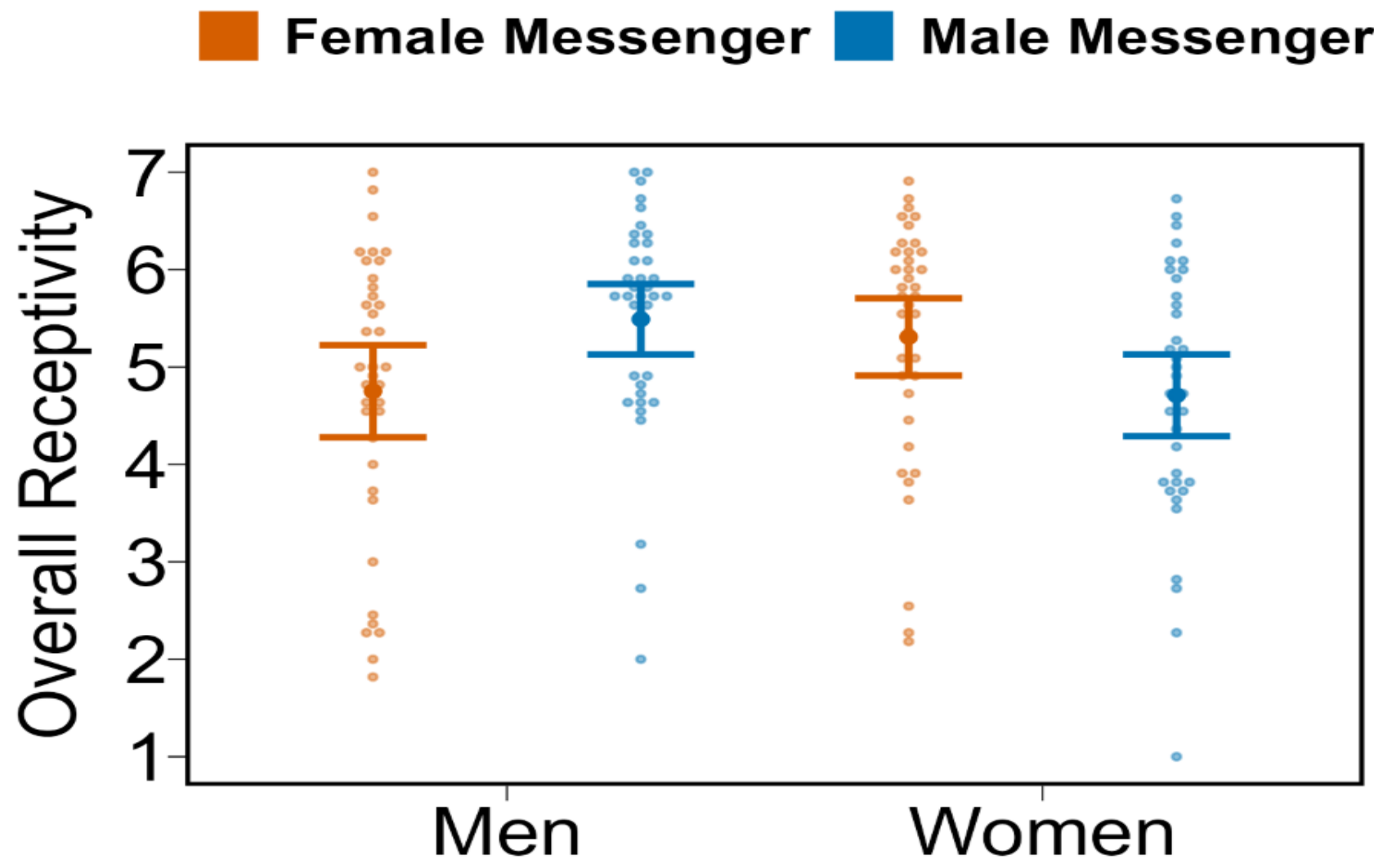
Note. (3a) Women were less receptive, on average, when the messenger was a male professor rather than a female professor ($p = .003$, $d = 0.33$). Men showed a similar pattern of results, but the difference was smaller and not statistically significant ($p = .235$).

College students: (1b) Women wanted to censor the messenger more than men did ($p < .001$, $d = .57$), but (2b) participants were equally censorious toward the male and female messenger ($p = .070$).



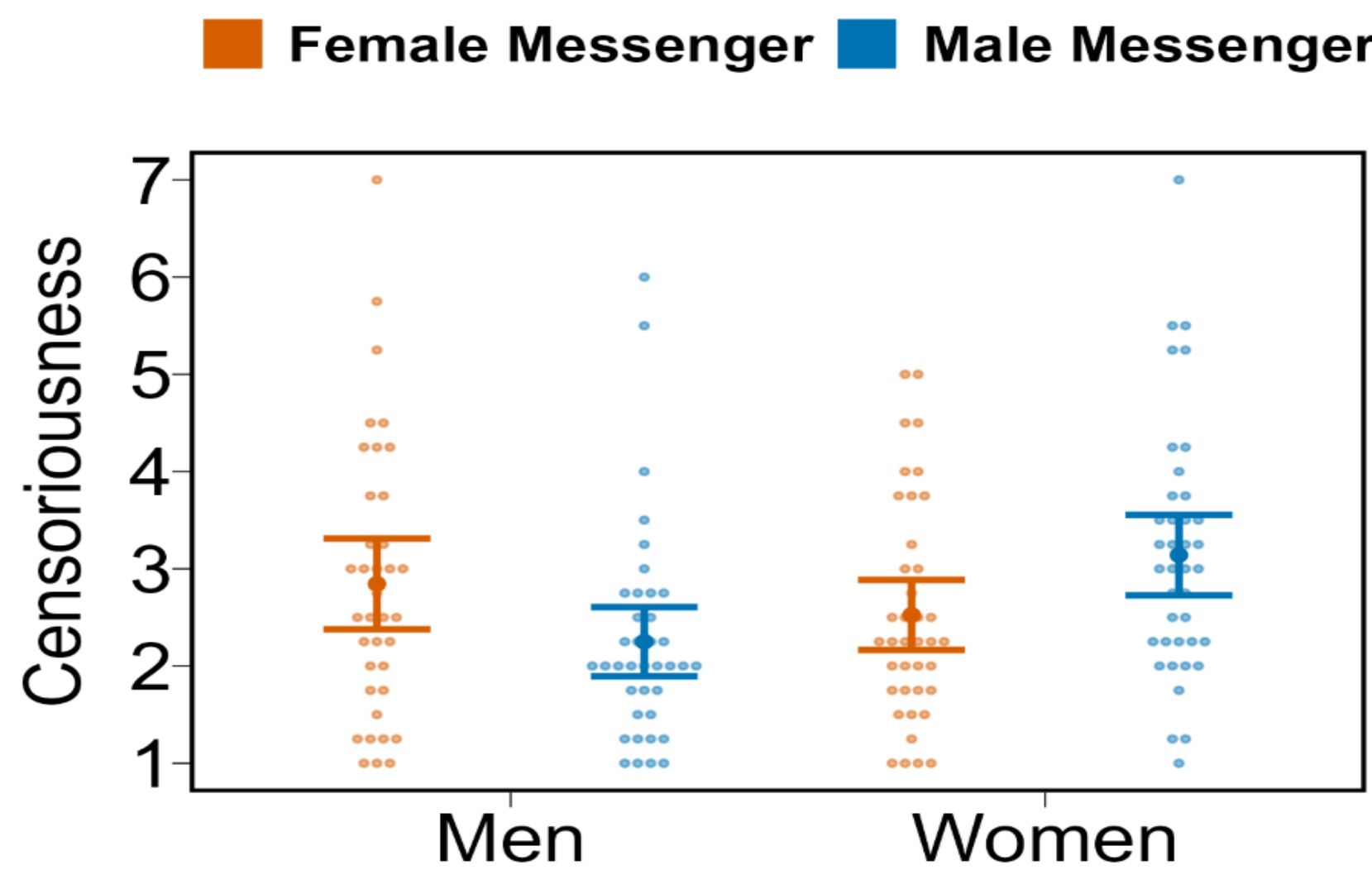
Note. (3b) Women were more censorious, on average, when the messenger was male rather than female ($p = .027$, $d = -0.27$). Men showed a similar pattern of results, but the difference was smaller and not statistically significant ($p = .444$).

Community adults: (1a) Women and men did not differ in their receptivity ($p = .594$) and (2a) participants did not differ in their receptivity to the male versus female messenger ($p = .740$).



Note. Both men and women were less receptive to the messenger that did not match their gender. (3a) As predicted, women were less receptive, on average, when the messenger was male rather than female ($p = .023$, $d = 0.47$). Unexpectedly, men were less receptive when the messenger was female rather than male ($p = .015$, $d = -0.58$).

Community adults: (1b) Women and men did not differ in their censoriousness toward the messenger ($p = .155$) and (2b) participants did not differ in their censoriousness toward the male versus female messenger ($p = .959$).



Note. Both men and women were more censorious toward the messenger that did not match their gender. (3b) As predicted, women were more censorious toward the male messenger than the female messenger ($p = .028$, $d = -0.51$). Again, unexpectedly, men were more censorious toward the female messenger ($p = .046$, $d = 0.47$).

Simultaneous multiple regression analyses show that participant gender, the belief that words can cause harm, and political orientation are all unique predictors of receptivity and censoriousness. Although, as seen in the table below, the effects are not consistent. Despite that, there is still partial support that left-leaning participants were (4a) less receptive and (4b) more censorious and that participants with a stronger belief that words can cause harm were (5a) less receptive and (5b) more censorious. Notably, the predictor variables together account for more variance in receptivity and censoriousness when the messenger was male, compared to when the messenger was female.

	College Students' Receptivity					Community Adults' Receptivity			
	Female Messenger		Male Messenger			Female Messenger		Male Messenger	
	Unstandardized B [95% CI]	p	Unstandardized B [95% CI]	p		Unstandardized B [95% CI]	p	Unstandardized B [95% CI]	p
Gender (F-M)	-.40 [-.74, -.06]	.020*	-.28 [-.63, .08]	.124		.61 [-.00, 1.23]	.052	-.58 [-1.11, -.05]	.033*
Words Can Harm	-.14 [-.29, .01]	.069	-.37 [-.54, -.20]	<.001*		-.25 [-.50, -.01]	.042*	-.18 [-.39, .02]	.081
Political Leaning	-.02 [-.18, .14]	.833	.10 [-.08, .27]	.278		.13 [-.13, .40]	.321	.34 [.06, .63]	.019*
Total R²	.07		.19			.13		.25	
	College Students' Censoriousness					Community Adults' Censoriousness			
Gender (F-M)	.46 [.04, .88]	.032*	.51 [.05, .97]	.029*		-.44 [-1.01, .12]	.120	.68 [.17, 1.20]	.010*
Words Can Harm	.19 [.00, .38]	.050	.22 [.00, .45]	.047*		.38 [.16, .61]	<.001*	.22 [.03, .42]	.026*
Political Leaning	-.03 [-.22, .17]	.796	-.27 [-.49, -.04]	.023*		-.04 [-.28, .21]	.772	-.29 [-.56, -.01]	.045*
Total R²	.07		.14			.17		.27	

Discussion

- The current research supports the general proposal that people’s response to scientific claims of truth can depend on the claimant’s identity.
- In addition, this research shows that people’s own gender identity, political views, and belief that words can cause harm can relate to how they respond to scientific information.
- Presuming that psychological scientists succumb to the same biases that others do, it is important to consider how harm concerns and identity-based biases might be shaping the production and dissemination of knowledge about human behavior.

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Manuscript (under review) and supplemental materials:

